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【メール原文】

dear hondo-san, my roundup of the united nations general assembly...with geopolitics and artificial intelligence in the mix. and president trump's really big, not-all

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dear hondo-san,

my roundup of the united nations general assembly...with geopolitics and artificial intelligence in the mix. and president trump's really big, not-all-that-eventful summit with chinese president xi jinning.

un high level week

i met with some 40 heads of state and foreign ministers over the course of the week (a bunch of whom trekked down to the west village for our annual "funga," making life that much sillier). to go around the horn...

from the united states, president trump's speech was less impactful than the previous year. his "man of action" focused on getting things done, including peace deals...but absent the significant announcements from the previous year (and with a new war he started going on in iran). trump's gaza progress and gulf summit were legitimate applause lines for the assembled leaders at last year's plenary; this year it was recounting wins in latin america (viewed positively in most of the region but not by most of the other member states in attendance) and resolving a greenland crisis he had started nearly a year ago (a welcome development, particularly for the europeans, but with little strategic significance).

trump's public focus remains unilateralism—a rejection of global governance, instead promoting a view that powerful countries get to set the rules to their liking, whatever their political and economic systems, anchored by a broader more zero-sum perspective of the economy, technology, and security. leaving aside the xi summit in washington (i'll get to that in a moment), the principal focus of his trip was the middle east, and the "decision" trump said he needs to take on further negotiations or the destruction of the iranian regime.

meanwhile president trump's choice to invite russian president vladimir putin to the g20 in miami helps with a long-term putin goal: for russia to be reaccepted into the international architecture. european leaders privately oppose the move (much as they did trump's invitation to putin for a summit in anchorage), but none are planning to boycott; instead they'll try to put a more constructive frame on a move to diplomacy to end russia's four plus year war on ukraine. trump intends to use the meeting to burnish his peacemaking bona fides and restart business ties (especially personal/family business ties) with the kremlin. the biggest concern is that the war continues to escalate and trump's response tilts toward the kremlin: already having singled out ukraine for their attacks on russian refineries (one of many reasons diesel prices are now at record levels) without a focus on the russian expansion of drone strikes on ukrainian civilians and architecture. further russian strikes, including direct kinetic attacks on nato countries, would likely be met with trump saying "all of this is horrible, that's why we need a ceasefire now," while leaving nato fending more for itself absent a diplomatic agreement.

on this front, also notable that there's been significant talk of the white house coordinating with the kremlin around the next secretary general of the united nations, with the intention being to veto the candidates presently making their way through the straw polls, and instead bring in an outside, weak/aligned leader that the americans can control (and potentially profit from). a number of names have been floated, among the more serious including board of peace director nikolay mladenov; turkey foreign minister and former national intelligence head hakan fidan. the chinese oppose this development: as the americans step away from the united nations, china is more interested in increasing their influence in a more effective and stronger organization...which means a globally respected, independent voice (since there's no way china could bring someone in who they control).

and yet there was less panic and urgency from most leaders i spoke with, given the lack of coherence and mental health concerns from the us leader (several heads of state who met with him told me about his deteriorating coherence, one told me in seriousness he thinks the president has alzheimers), and the expected drubbing in the upcoming november midterm elections (where it now looks likely that the democrats will flip both the house and senate). yes, many worry that trump could become even more vindictive and unconstrained in that environment (though with the baseline being a high bar, it's worth thinking about what concretely is meant by that), but it's more likely that such behaviors give domestic and international political leaders interested in jumping ship a more readymade excuse to do so.

i'd also note how much foreign leaders see these policies being driven absent secretary of state/national security advisor marco rubio. essentially, if it's a policy that's going badly and/or likely problematic long term, rubio is keeping a low profile—whether iran, gaza, russia/ukraine, or china—a remarkable thing when you consider his portfolio. rubio is driving much of the latin america policy personally (alongside white house deputy chief of staff stephen miller, depending on the issue), and also has the state department pushing areas of smaller engagement where trump isn't focused (the sahel, critical minerals with sub-saharan africa, the arctic, etc) but overall he's steering clear, a strategy consistent with a recognition that he is better served sitting out 2028 with his reputation largely intact.

middle east leaders are focused on the need to resolve the conflicts in their region themselves, with disappointment in the united states and little expectation from anyone else. most dramatically, the saudis thought they would get direct support from the united states when the houthis (with iranian support) started hitting them directly; president trump initially responded favorably, supporting direct military engagement and with bombers scrambled accordingly...but changed his mind before he gave the final go ahead, instead supporting a sale of additional military equipment (which will take years) and focusing on protecting american ships but not those of a key ally.

i heard louder concerns of us unilateralism from across the region—close us allies are bearing the cost of the iran war (though leavened by the recent increases in oil transiting through the strait), while president trump is unwilling to give them a say on the policies affecting their region, put pressure on israel, or even provide transparency on what the united states is doing (presuming the advisors know). that qatar was leading diplomatic efforts between the united states and iran—at the direct request of the white house—when the white house decided to launch decapitation strikes and not tell them anything about it, shows both indifference to their interests and a lack of trust. meanwhile, china has recently talked more about their desire to bring the iran war to a close, and their potential to engage in direct diplomacy in support of that...but gulf leaders haven't seen any of that in their meetings and are skeptical.

also regional anger at israel, and prime minister netanyahu in particular, is higher than i've seen it before. in campaign mode, netanyahu's unga visit ignored regional officials (though he did visit the uae,

israel's abraham accords partner, after returning to the region), instead meeting with a few right-wing friends like argentina president javier milei...and using his speech to go after new york mayor zohran mamdani, while continuing to push the need for further attacks. israel's european friends are looking for anything they can get to reduce the pressure from their voters (on gaza, west bank settlements, lebanon, syria, and the like), which netanyahu listened to and then proceeded with his own message...including a continued effort to bring about regime change in iran, and a growing drumbeat for a fight with turkey's recep erdoğan (who he sees as neo-ottoman expansionist—from damascus to jerusalem) that he believes the world should consider as dangerous as russia's putin. all of which is pointing toward a stronger breakdown of the middle east into competing security blocs.

for china, the priorities of foreign minister wang yi's bilateral meetings were artificial intelligence and, second, taiwan. in both cases, china brought confidence to its meetings and came with clear agenda. the takeaways from foreign leaders were a level of pragmatism in understanding the political pressures they are under on other, subsidiary issues (including direct trade, transshipment of goods, and the like); but with a clear message that there's a choice to be made and only one side that's acceptable. they've won that framing on taiwan but are still pushing the overall fight...since a full rejection of taiwanese independence puts the well-resourced taiwanese in more of a corner long term. while on ai it's early days, and a china that's well ahead of the global south sees itself as educating as much as implementing (or threatening), to convince other countries that they are the clear smarter, cheaper choice.

on russia/ukraine, i heard two very different narratives. as ukraine is hitting russia hard and the economy starts taking a serious hit, causing anger and anxiety among the russian population. but the view getting more urgent focus among leaders was russia now ramping up their war economy and military tech innovation in ways that are more dangerous to a smaller and more vulnerable ukrainian economy—with ukraine's ports now shut down and exports throttled, electricity grid taking bigger hits, steel production offline. it's a shift from war on the front lines to total war...an escalation that's not getting the attention it now deserves given the implications a year down the road.

the europeans had more of a spring in their step than you might think. the focus remains the united states, but they see a weakened, less focused trump as the beginning of the end of this particular period of uncertainty. they're convinced they can continue to support the ukrainians to fight and defend themselves against russia, which itself is now starting to feel real economic pain (russia's just mentioned escalations notwithstanding). and they're less worried than their asian peers (though still concerned around strategic industries) that china is about to take over.

europe still has slower growth and lower productivity than the americans to be sure. but they have now made more progress on the draghi plan to address those issues structurally than most would have expected a few years ago—pressing ahead with a capital markets in the e6 (the eu's six largest economies) and coordination on more forceful industrial policies (as china and the united states have been doing for some time), to leverage the continent's large single market for the benefit of european firms. and while there are real and present political dangers inside europe—the rise of the afd in germany, the possibility that france's coming elections return a national rally presidency—they're balanced by the end of orban in hungary; the decline of nigel farage's reform party and fragmentation of the right in the united kingdom; a likely center right victory in spain; the canadians wanting to join europe and opening the door for others; and the continued power of the center right in a complicated and divided (200 parties in all!) european parliament.

that's still far from a global middle power strategy. and yet the fact that the europeans are only more strongly aligned on rule of law, the importance of multilateralism, governance for artificial intelligence,

and the effectiveness of civil society and a social contract, makes them more significant as actors on the united nations stage than you might think. to the extent that the week brought meaningful efforts at new international resilience and cooperation, the europeans were involved in most of them. europe's principal challenges are on the technology side, where they're calling for new rules (and with a useful joint ai governance statement from finland and norway with a broad group of signatories)...but they have neither the power nor the scale to set the agenda.

artificial intelligence

the ceos of open ai and anthropic addressed the un security council in one of the most anticipated and discussed sessions of the week, repeating the broader concerns about the destructive capabilities of ai—while the american tech ceos gathered at the white house to meet with xi Jinping later in the week were the ones focused on ensuring there's no governance (or as president trump said, leaving ai "exactly where it is."

many of the tech ceos are pivoting, bringing up concerns that the science of the frontier is moving significantly faster than the science of understanding what they can do to maintain security...and so the companies need to "slow things down." i see much of the p(doom) conversation as shifting the focus; there's an existential danger from ai...but the risks fueling it come from the companies that are programming, testing, and releasing the models; the customers that use (and misuse) them; and the lack of oversight and control on that process. an additional breach announced during the un week—that an open ai model had hacked into the australian government public healthcare system back in august (and open ai knew about it...but hadn't informed the australians for a month) is another urgent warning that these governments, (non-ai) companies and citizens are not the principal actors in this rollout and have ceded core sovereignty, whether they know it or not. and so, the drumbeat demanding some level of accountability is set to grow dramatically in the coming months.

i see two additional vectors for this near-term impact. first, an explosion of dangerous cyber incidents. the issue here is less a new vulnerability than the actors and motivations. over the last decade, the overwhelming focus of cyberhackers has been making money (hacking and demanding ransom, or else) or espionage (lurking for years to steal ip). both of these are aligned toward the stability of the system: ransomware doesn't work if people don't pay; the intention is to keep the system intact...and indeed not even have the public find out the attack occurred. espionage even more so—you don't want to destroy the competitor, you want to stay in the system, keep grabbing sensitive data that you can benefit from, and preferably never have the adversary even know that there's a hack. that's all problematic for the global economy and security, but neither are core threats to the international system.

but now that you have ai tools making cyberhacking capabilities available to most anyone that wants to engage (and not just through mythos and the most advanced models, but even more basic frontier and open-source models); you have governments, institutions and individuals with a much broader array of interests and ideologies that can deploy them. some of whom aren't motivated by profit or long-term advantage, but by damaging or destroying a powerful entity that they for some reason disagree with—they've been attacked, taken advantage of, lost a lawsuit, you name it. not to mention the risk of agents doing something actively harmful in pursuit of whatever goal it happens to be programmed to prioritize. these aren't systemic long-term risks, both because the most powerful institutions are taking this extremely seriously and working to plug vulnerabilities as soon as possible...and because we'll quickly see an ai cyber industry that makes cybersecurity considerably more robust. but in the nearer future, this is the principal ai risk out there, and one that's going to immediately lead to popular

backlash for governance and regulation.

a second is the fact that the chinese are winning the ai war politically. technology is challenging—we don't know whether closed or open-source models will carry the day in another year or two. it's unclear how effective china will be at improving their semiconductors, and how much cheaper available energy and compute will drive outcomes. but the chinese people are far more supportive of ai than the americans are. the data is overwhelming—well over 90% of chinese are optimistic about ai, want to use it (and a larger percentage use it than americans do, and for more things, despite being a middle-income country), and trust that it will improve their and their country's future. not in small part because china's undergoing a massive population and workforce contraction, so the ai boom is fully aligned with the policy changes required to increase productivity for the domestic economy. that's very different than the us environment...and support for ai has become a minority position across the board in the united states.

i don't believe this is about americans suddenly mistrusting technology. it's more problematic than that. it's americans mistrusting that their leaders, the people with power and money, will use artificial intelligence in ways that benefit the interests of most americans. and so, they're becoming opposed to whatever those people are telling them. this is an essential political driver for the coming presidential race. meanwhile china, which leads the world in surveillance technology and deploying the data revolution, is also showing the chinese that they can use ai in ways that benefit them already—made easier by coordinated and effective ai deployment on superapps, where chinese citizens already conduct a much greater percentage of their commerce.

a contrast which is particularly important given the most important meeting of the week...

trump - xi

a successful and uneventful us-china summit, as expected. with president trump literally rolling out the red carpet, the first time a us president has greeted a visiting head of state (if you don't count popes) for a state visit since john f. kennedy did for uk prime minister harold macmillan in 1962. especially striking when you realize it wasn't reciprocated for trump when he visited beijing back a couple months ago.

the trip was all about the ceremony. the chinese didn't bring a big delegation of ceos (as the united states did to beijing); nor did they come with specific new diplomatic or economic asks to be resolved at the summit (with secretary of state marco rubio telling attendees all was well and president trump couldn't have been happier with the outcome; secretary of treasury scott bessent cautioning the water was calm but there was lots of kicking under the surface). rather they brought chairman xi saying how much he respected and liked trump and would ensure stable relations going forward. with no agreement on ai (where china is happy to watch the americans fight among themselves...and with allies), and a two-month extension of the truce on trade—suspending tariffs, export controls, and port fees—so at least they both have something else to announce when they meet twice more in the coming months).

for now, it's a short-term focus for the american president (ownership of tiktok, chinese purchases of soybeans, critical mineral access, and the like); while the chinese president focuses on improving china's long-term position on taiwan, in multilateral architecture, in global energy, and on artificial intelligence. very much unlike other core adversarial relationships, where the leaders are fighting over mutually exclusive terms (control of land for russia/ukraine; control of the strait for us/iran); the mismatch of short and long-term interests for trump and xi works well...for now. the big concern is that

the approach risks greater conflict as the broader issues remain unaddressed...and as the us and chinese strategic power positions become more unaligned and confrontational. i would love to be wrong about this.

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i'm in austin today for some meetings and a speech. heading to europe, first switzerland and then london where eurasia group is hosting our gzero summit.

very best,

ian

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